COCAINE

Also known as COKE, CHARLIE, BLOW or SNOW

KNOW THE RISKS

Cocaine is a powerful stimulant. It can cause dependence and serious heart, brain and mental health problems - even in people who use it occasionally.

WHAT IS COCAINE?

Cocaine is a Class A drug that usually appears as a white powder. It is commonly snorted; some forms are smoked or injected. Its strength and contents are unpredictable.

IMMEDIATE EFFECTS

A brief rush of energy or confidence may be followed by anxiety, agitation, paranoia, a racing heartbeat, raised blood pressure or a low mood.

HEART & BRAIN RISKS

Cocaine can trigger an abnormal heart rhythm, chest pain, heart attack, stroke or seizure. These emergencies can happen even after a single use.

DEPENDENCE & THE COMEDOWN

Cravings and repeated use can develop quickly. Afterwards, people may experience exhaustion, anxiety, low mood, poor sleep and irritability.

ALCOHOL & OTHER DRUGS

Combining cocaine with alcohol produces cocaethylene, which increases strain on the heart. Mixing substances makes the risks harder to predict.

WARNING SIGNS - DO NOT IGNORE

Chest pain, severe headache, seizures, collapse, overheating, difficulty breathing, sudden confusion or weakness on one side of the body are emergency warning signs. Call 999.

THE KEY MESSAGE

A short-lived high can have lasting consequences. Seek support early, without shame or judgement.

RECOGNISE THE SIGNS. GET HELP EARLY.

Practical information for individuals, parents and families.

WHEN TO SEEK URGENT HELP

Call 999 for chest pain, collapse, seizures, severe breathing problems, or signs of a stroke. Tell paramedics what may have been taken. Do not leave an unconscious person alone.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

If cocaine is affecting your sleep, mood, finances, work or relationships, contact a GP or local drug service. Families: ask calm questions, listen first, and avoid threats or shaming. Do not drive while affected.

UK LAW | ENGLAND & WALES

Cocaine is a Class A controlled drug. These are maximum penalties unless stated otherwise.

POSSESSION	Up to 7 years in prison, an unlimited fine, or both.
SELLING / SUPPLY	Up to life imprisonment, an unlimited fine, or both.
DRUG-DRIVING	Minimum 1-year ban; up to 6 months in prison, an unlimited fine and a criminal record.

Driving above the specified cocaine blood limit is an offence, even without obvious impairment. Police can screen for cocaine at the roadside.

FAMILIES, STIGMA & SUPPORT

Cocaine use may be hidden because of fear, embarrassment or family honour. Serious health problems deserve medical care, not blame. A private conversation can help someone accept support.

LOCAL SUPPORT IN ROCHDALE

TURNING POINT / ROAR Adults - drug and alcohol recovery	**0300 555 0234**
EARLY BREAK Young people and families	**0161 723 3880**

Seeking help is a sign of strength, not shame.

Sources: NHS cocaine guidance; GOV.UK drug penalties and drug-driving law; NHS local service listings (2026).